



Emotional Design, Storytelling, 'Slippiness,' and Understandable Icons

Regardless of how many usability studies you've conducted or how much you've incorporated UX (user experience) concepts into your design process, there's always more to learn. New practices in the field and research results from the lab suggest different approaches to usability and UX, even when using familiar tools.

UX looks at how users feel about using or considering using a particular product, service, or bundle of services under one brand. Think for a moment about how you react to the thought of using an iPhone, booking flights on an airline website, or writing a report in Microsoft Word. Which of these do you like to use? Understanding how users feel when it comes to your library's website is a key piece in knowing what motivates them to take action. Learning more about our users helps us create designs that engage users in a way that not only works for them but also invokes actions and responses that lead to a delightful, harmonious experience.

The UX field is looking more and more at holistic ways of assessing users' interactions with products and services. It is developing new tactics and approaches, taking into account not only the how ("the user clicked here and then here") but also the why ("the user responded positively to the attractive hero image"). It's what people were thinking and feeling during and after these interactions that's becoming more of interest.

UX is looking at the delight factor—delighted users are your allies and friends. People will remember how they feel long after they remember the particular details of what they were doing. They'll remember that the library study rooms were a great place to study, not what they were studying. They'll remember whether they were convinced that they could find what they wanted when doing research with library tools (or not).

New developments in, approaches to, and methodologies with emotional design, storytelling, "slippiness," and understandable icons recently caught our attention, and we think they can improve your library sites and services.

I'VE GOT A FEELING

Usability testing is essential—websites need to be usable in order to be minimally effective. Usability is a baseline to work from, one dimension among many that we ought to be considering when designing our digital or even offline products and services.

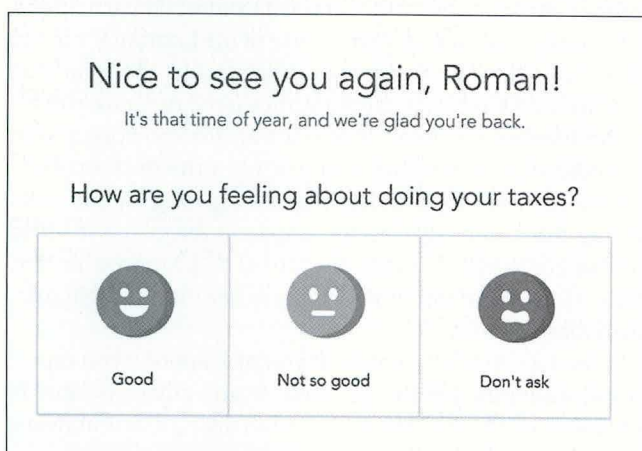
An area of increasing focus in the UX world is emotional design, which assumes that you already have a product that's functional and usable. If those two conditions aren't met, your design will elicit only negative emotions such as frustration, maybe even hatred. Fruitlessly looking around an unusable website trying to find the link to download the form you need does not a delightful experience make.

Assuming, then, that you've created a usable site, emotional design seeks to



Among the newer methods and approaches are emotional design, storytelling, 'slippiness,' and understandable icons.

elevate the user experience beyond the utilitarian and into the realm of creating the warm fuzzies. Another way to express this idea is to say that emotional design seeks to create human-to-machine interactions that feel more like human-to-human ones. Empathy is key, so while we usually seek to elicit positive emotions, acknowledging unavoidably negative ones is also valid. Intuit's TurboTax is one example of this. At the beginning of the tax-filing process, the software asks how you're feeling about doing your taxes. The choices? Good, not so good, and don't ask. Not so good and don't ask are not positive, but by acknowledging that many users are never going to feel positive about doing their taxes, Intuit has avoided "marketing" (taxes are great!) and created an empathetic, human, emotional moment. Intuit's designers refer to this as "leaning into the emotion." A few examples of places where libraries can seek to emulate this emotional approach include starting a research paper, looking for a job, and, yes, tax help.



TurboTax has long experimented with emotional design principles.

Although emotional design is not a brand-new concept—it's been around for more than 20 years—the design world is taking emotional design more and more seriously. Connecting with users on this level is extremely powerful. Designers are developing tools to help track and measure emotional response to websites. A soon-to-be released cloud-based tool called Emotie (emotietool.com) intends to provide researchers with a simple tool for tracking and communicating people's emotional state. The product page for Emotie describes it as "a research tool that will allow participants to self-report emotions, removing the level of subjectivity that surrounds moderator interpreting emotions." There will be other tools coming down the pike as well, so it may be a good idea to consider adding one or more of these to your UX toolbox.

TELL ME A STORY

Emotional design has legs because it's fundamentally human. Much as we'd like to think otherwise, we are fundamentally emotional beings. To that end, another design principle getting a lot of attention is the use of storytelling as

an organizing principle. Stories are as old as humanity itself, but it's only recently that the web design community moved from basic utility to emotional design to, essentially, taking users on a virtual journey to more deeply and satisfyingly connect, inform, and engage. It's a big-picture approach, with a beginning, middle, and an end.

This orientation leverages the principles of emotional design but puts the whole in a larger context. On an academic library website, for example, it's the difference between a traditional list of services for faculty and a faculty website that's organized according to the research lifecycle, the "story" of how they conduct their research activities. It's user-centered, not organization-centered, and attempts to unify around a story that has meaning for them.

Simplified, the beginning is the research idea, the middle is the research itself, and the end is the article, the dissemination, and the spread of the idea. As with any other UX technique, this one will fail if there's not a solid foundation of usability behind it, so good information architecture and well-written content (in simple language and from the user's perspective) become a starting point instead of an end point.

I WANT A 'SLIPPY' UX

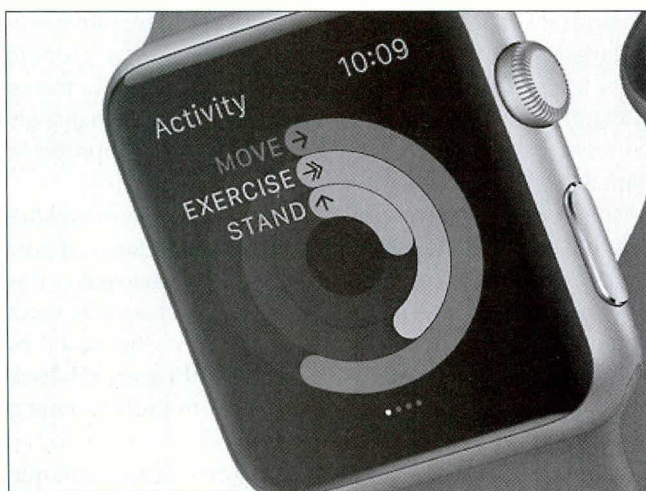
Jake Zukowski, assistant creative director at Frog Design, coined the term "slippy UX" to describe designing interactions that are very brief, have a low focus of attention, and require minimal copy. His example is designing car play messages for automobiles (vimeo.com/113120075) so that drivers absorb the information at a glance.

"Slippy" experiences are positioned in stark contrast to "sticky" ones, a key design goal for many websites, where engaging visitors and keeping them on the site longer leads to greater loyalty, sales, and return visits. *UX Magazine* contributor Shannon Copfer included slippy UX in the December 2014 issue's article "The Top UX Predictions for 2015" (uxmag.com/articles/the-top-ux-predictions-for-2015).

Some UX designers point out that "slippy" is not new. For years, designers have used slippy approaches when the context and interaction needed this method. What is new about "slippy" is its fun name and the explosion of new devices that will need this approach—from wearables to cars to smart homes and the Internet of Things. We want low engagement and minimal interactions with these devices. An example of slippy UX at work is the three rings displayed by Apple Watch Fitness App that track your time moving, exercising, or standing (apple.com/watch/health-and-fitness).

The opportunities to apply slippy UX in libraries are all around us. Whether it's designing for beacons in libraries (discussed in our last column), wayfinding apps on smartphones, or account dashboards on the web or online, slippy UX techniques help create a harmonious experience that not only works but also does so with finesse.

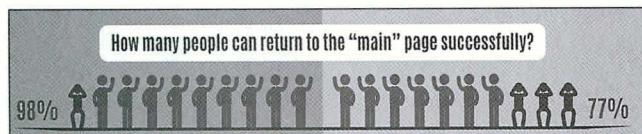
To truly work well, many of the new wearables and devices will draw minimal attention to themselves and remain largely invisible, becoming visible briefly only when needed.



The Apple Watch Fitness App uses “slippy” design, exemplified by the three rings that track your time moving, exercising, or standing.

HOME AGAIN, HOME AGAIN

Recently, Danielle Cooley presented research results at the San Diego UXPA conference about whether or not it's necessary to include a “Home” option on the navigation menu. While many web designers have a sense this is important and that relying on the site's logo as a way to return to the homepage is not sufficient, until now there was no empirical evidence. A snippet from her poster (created along with Nikki Bristol) showed that when the Home option was available on the menu, 98% of users returned successfully to the main page versus 77% that only had the logo (static1.1.sqspcdn.com/static/f/1044580/26351202/1435541047643/uxpa_poster_ol.pdf?token=OQmDWKKCGrbagKHw8aP84Ev%2BKcE%3D).



The left-hand side reports websites with “Home” on the navigation menu compared with those on the right that reports websites with a logo as the option to return home.

Not only were users more successful at returning to the main page with a Home menu option, they were also significantly quicker in doing so.

HAMBURGER MENU ICON OR ‘HAMBUNGLER’?

You’ve probably seen mobile and even websites that use a three-line icon that looks like a hamburger to open sliders when clicked. There are many reasons why the hamburger icon caught on. Real estate was a big one—how can you fit a menu and content on a small mobile screen? It provides a clean, uncluttered look. It allows for reuse of menus with responsive design. It has reasonable uptake on a number of apps so if people don’t know it, they’ll “learn about it.”

So it’s a good thing, right? Turns out not so much. In his presentation at UXPA 2015, Mike Ryan took a comprehensive look at the evidence for and against using a hamburger menu on devices and concluded that it needs to disappear (slideshare.net/ryaninteractive/hamburger-wars-5-2015). Noted web designer Jared Spool chimed about the hamburger icon in a March 5, 2014, tweet (twitter.com/jmspool/status/441224973047574528):



Jared Spool
@jmspool



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The hamburger icon is the 2014 technique for providing mystery meat navigation. (And, thus, appropriately named.)

Ryan said results of six usability tests carried out from December 2013 to June 2014 showed 71 out of 76 participants failed tasks when it required the use of the hamburger menu icon. Users don’t know what to expect under the icon and, once they do look at its contents, they need to memorize it.

The hamburger menu is also a trap for developers who can take an easy way out and just plop the desktop website menu on the mobile, leading to long, long menus. After testing the hamburger menu, apps are removing it—iPad in May 2015, NBC News in July 2014, and Amazon in May 2015. Most of the top iPhone apps other than Google ones use a tabbed menu.

In the face of the evidence, if you or someone you report to still wants the hamburger icon, Ryan’s advice is label it: Add the word “Menu.” We recommend taking a look at Ryan’s full Slideshare presentation to learn more.

SOMETHING OLD, SOMETHING NEW

The field of web design is constantly evolving. Answers to questions old and new are discovered, and the field as a whole, as technology evolves, has gotten more and more sophisticated. From questions about basic interactivity and usability to looking at ways to connect more deeply with users, it’s no small irony that as technology itself has gotten more sophisticated, the web designer’s toolkit is increasingly outfitted with techniques and approaches that leverage the basics, such as ease of use, emotion, and stories, to transcend the virtual.

Whether the question is about a specific type of navigation menu or something larger, such as an overarching design principle, librarians in the web design field are better able than ever to make the online experience easy, engaging, impactful, and delightful.

Darlene Fichter (dfichter@gmail.com) is librarian, University of Saskatchewan Library. **Jeff Wisniewski** (jeffw@pitt.edu) is web services librarian, University Library System, University of Pittsburgh.

Comments? Email the editor-in-chief (marydee@xmission.com).

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